

Ancient Greek temples and theatres

Using a structural system of vertical columns and horizontal beams, the Greeks ensured architectural consistency and visual harmony. Their most important buildings were temples, closely followed by theatres, built on a range of scales.

The tiny temple of Athena Nike, built c.421 BCE to overlook Athens on one side and face the Acropolis on the other, has four Ionic columns to front and back, inspired by natural sources including rams' horns, shells and Egyptian lotus flowers. In contrast the temple of Concordia (440–430 BCE) at Agrigento, Sicily (opposite), is a well-preserved example of the Doric order. The massive temple of Artemis at Ephesus (c.356 BCE), one of the seven wonders of the ancient world, was reached by steps flanked with bronze Amazonian warrior statues. Its central span of more than 80 metres (260 ft) was supported by almost 120 gold-coated Ionic columns. The theatre of Epidauros (350 BCE) is an immense amphitheatre 118 metres (387 ft) across, with banked tiers of limestone seats and superb acoustic qualities.

